Claude Code (for normal people)

charliehills.substack.com/p/460c3f4e-fd6f-4315-ade6-e353f041e8e0

Charlie Hills May 10, 2026

6 weeks ago, I co-wrote a newsletter about Claude Code.

I called it “Beginner to Advanced”.

I was the beginner…

Six weeks later, I am still not the advanced one. But **Claude Code now runs about 80% of my content business.**

Claude Code is genuinely easy. The CLI (Command Line Interface) is just another text box. *You type what you want. Claude does it.* That is how it works.

The fear is the only thing in your way.

Below are the **6 features** that took me from terrified to fluent.

You will finish this email going *“oh, I can do that too”*.

Which Claude do you use daily?

I do not use Claude (yet)
If you are new here, welcome. If you have been reading for a while, thank you. Your subscription is what makes issues like this possible.

These are the 6 features to learn:

I recorded the **YouTube version** of this newsletter, walking through every feature with live demos inside Claude Code.

Honestly? If you would rather watch than read, *go straight to that*. The video shows the workflows in action, which is hard to convey in text.

1. Setup

First decision. How do you want to run it?

There are 4 ways. They all do the same job, just with different shoes on.

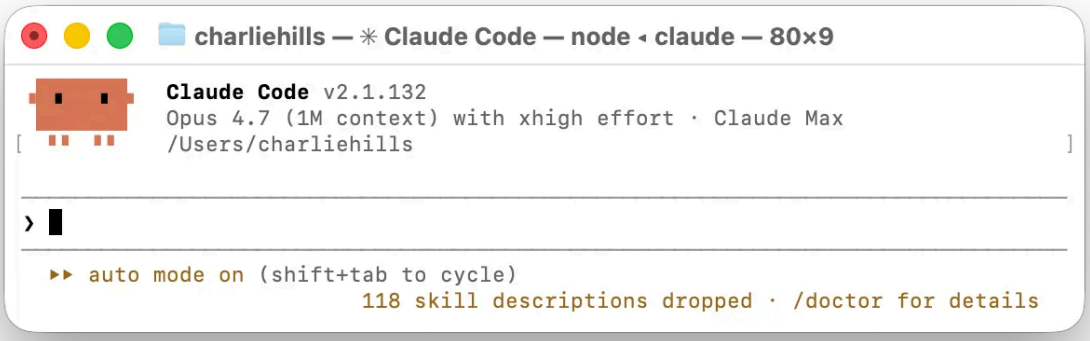
Terminal (CLI)

This is the fastest and most full-featured. I personally recommend the terminal, but it’s the steepest learning curve at first.

To install: open Terminal on your Mac (it is built in, search “Terminal” in Spotlight). Windows wants WSL or PowerShell. Then run:

> curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash

When that finishes, type “claude”. You are in.

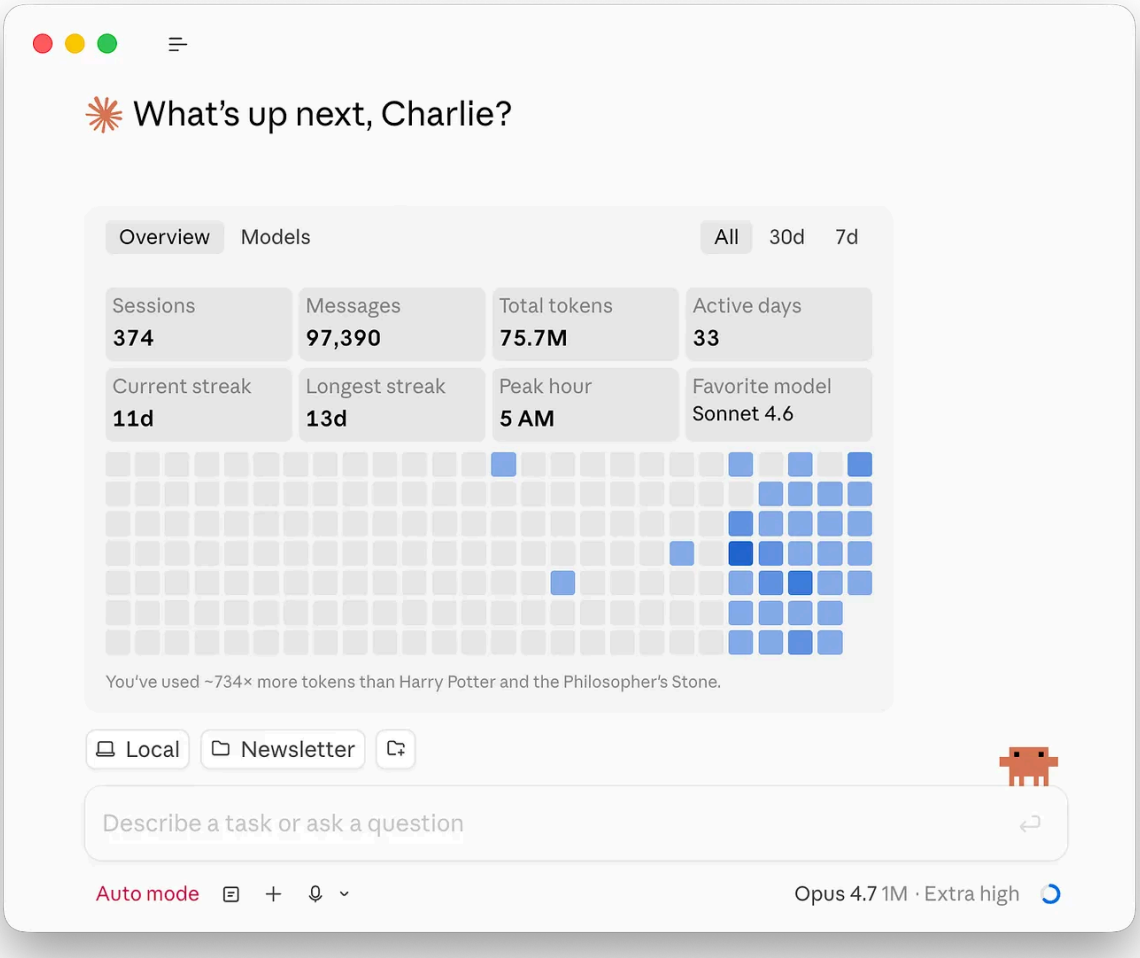


Desktop app

Native Mac or Windows app with a clean visual interface (no terminal anxiety).

The easiest place to start.

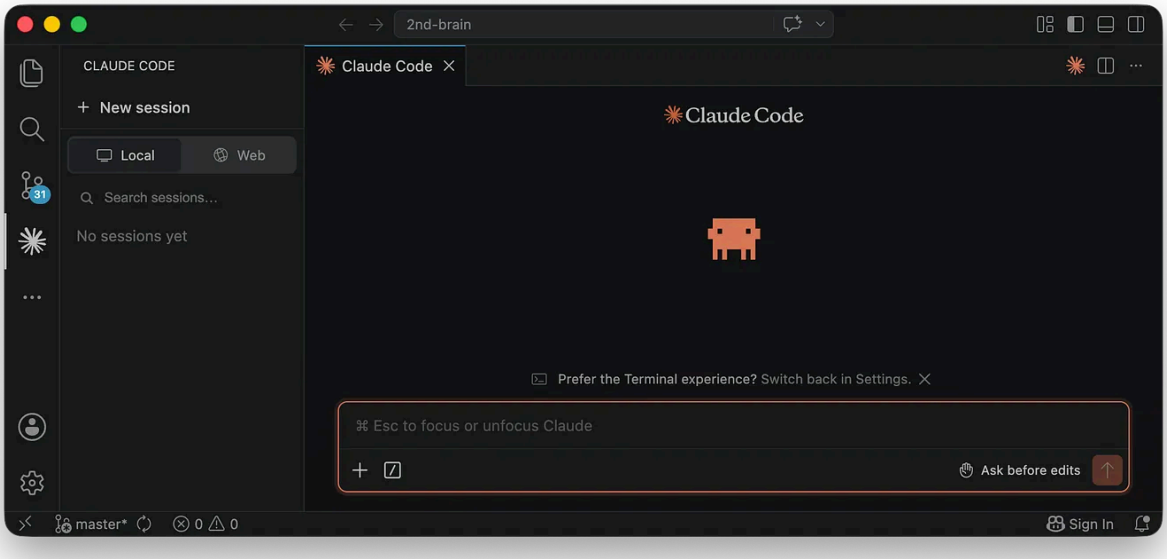
To install: go to claude.ai, download the app, double click, sign in. Done.



VS Code extension

Same engine, but inside your code editor. You see Claude editing files in real time alongside your own work, and you approve each change before it sticks.

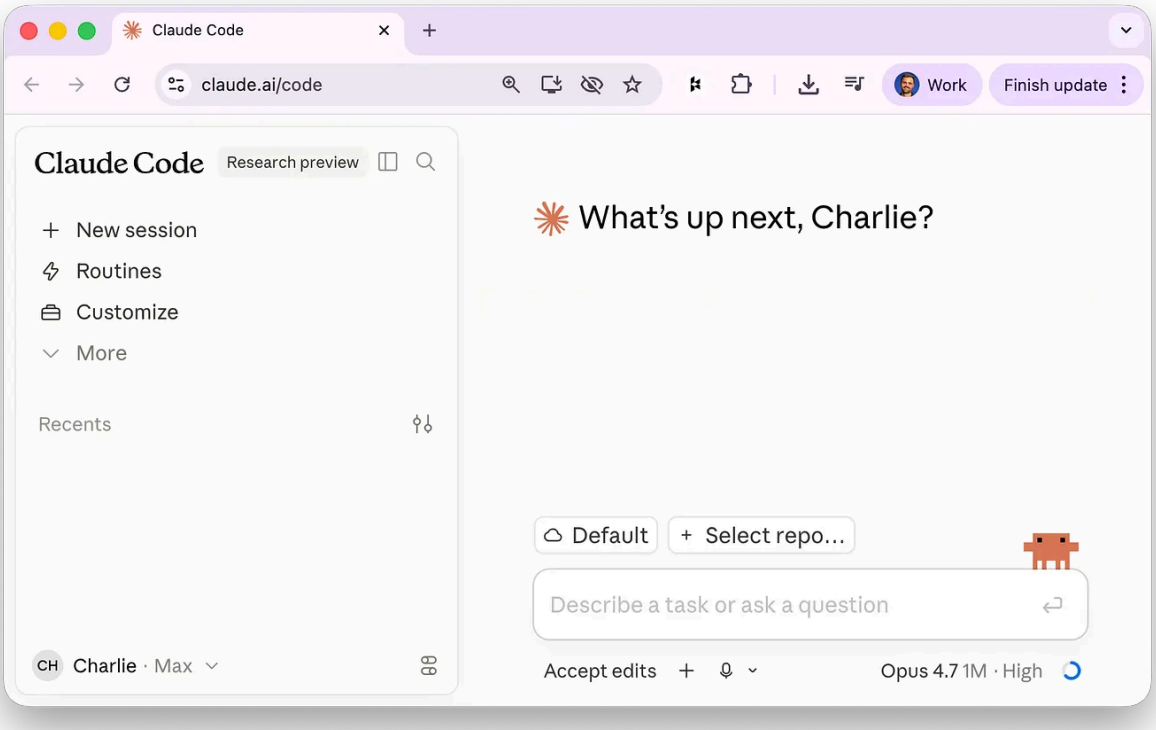
To install: install the terminal version first using the line above. Then add the “Claude Code for VS Code” extension by Anthropic from the marketplace. A Spark icon appears in the sidebar. Click it.



Web app at claude.ai/code

This runs in your browser, so no installation is needed. Probably the easiest way to try without committing.

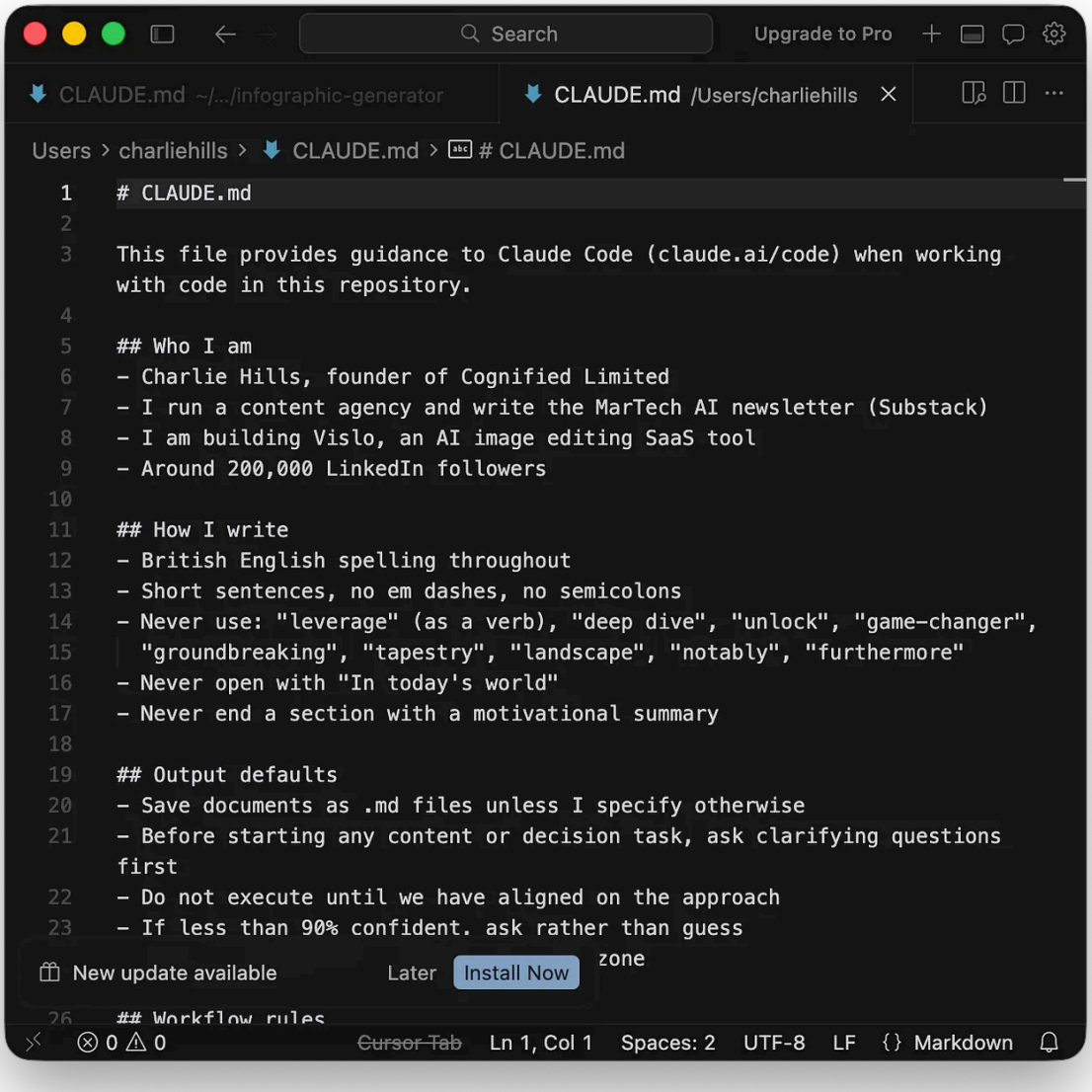
I use the terminal because I learned it that way. If I started today I would honestly use the desktop app.



Okay, now onto the secret sauce.

2. CLAUDE.md

Claude Code runs on plain text files that end in `.md`. **You do not write code. You write words.** The most important file is called **CLAUDE.md**.



It sits in your project folder. Claude reads it before every reply. Mine tells Claude *who I am, how I write, what to never do,* and how to handle every recurring task in my content business.

If you never write one. **Claude has no idea who you are.**

The build is simple. Create the file. Start writing. Then tell Claude:

> *"When you figure out a recurring pattern in our work, update CLAUDE.md so we do not have to redo this every session."*

It builds itself as you work.

If you want a strong starting template, save **Boris Cherny's CLAUDE.md** below. He built Claude Code. His version is engineering-focused, but the structure (workflow rules, task management, core principles) translates to any kind of work.

```
## Workflow Orchestration

### 1. Plan Node Default
- Enter plan mode for ANY non-trivial task (3+ steps or architectural decisions)
- If something goes sideways, STOP and re-plan immediately - don't keep pushing
- Use plan mode for verification steps, not just building
- Write detailed specs upfront to reduce ambiguity

### 2. Subagent Strategy
- Use subagents liberally to keep main context window clean
- Offload research, exploration, and parallel analysis to subagents
- For complex problems, throw more compute at it via subagents
- One tack per subagent for focused execution

### 3. Self-Improvement Loop
- After ANY correction from the user: update `tasks/lessons.md` with the pattern
- Write rules for yourself that prevent the same mistake
- Ruthlessly iterate on these lessons until mistake rate drops
- Review lessons at session start for relevant project

### 4. Verification Before Done
- Never mark a task complete without proving it works
- Diff behavior between main and your changes when relevant
- Ask yourself: "Would a staff engineer approve this?"
- Run tests, check logs, demonstrate correctness

### 5. Demand Elegance (Balanced)
- For non-trivial changes: pause and ask "is there a more elegant way?"
- If a fix feels hacky: "Knowing everything I know now, implement the elegant solution"
- Skip this for simple, obvious fixes - don't over-engineer
- Challenge your own work before presenting it

### 6. Autonomous Bug Fizing
- When given a bug report: just fix it. Don't ask for hand-holding
- Point at logs, errors, failing tests - then resolve them
- Zero context switching required from the user
- Go fix failing CI tests without being told how

## Task Management

1. **Plan First**: Write plan to `tasks/todo.md` with checkable items
2. **Verify Plan**: Check in before starting implementation
3. **Track Progress**: Mark items complete as you go
4. **Explain Changes**: High-level summary at each step
5. **Document Results**: Add review section to `tasks/todo.md`
6. **Capture Lessons**: Update `tasks/lessons.md` after corrections

## Core Principles

- **Simplicity First**: Make every change as simple as possible. Impact minimal code.
- **No Laziness**: Find root causes. No temporary fixes. Senior developer standards.
- **Minimat Impact**: Changes should only touch what's necessary. Avoid introducing bugs.
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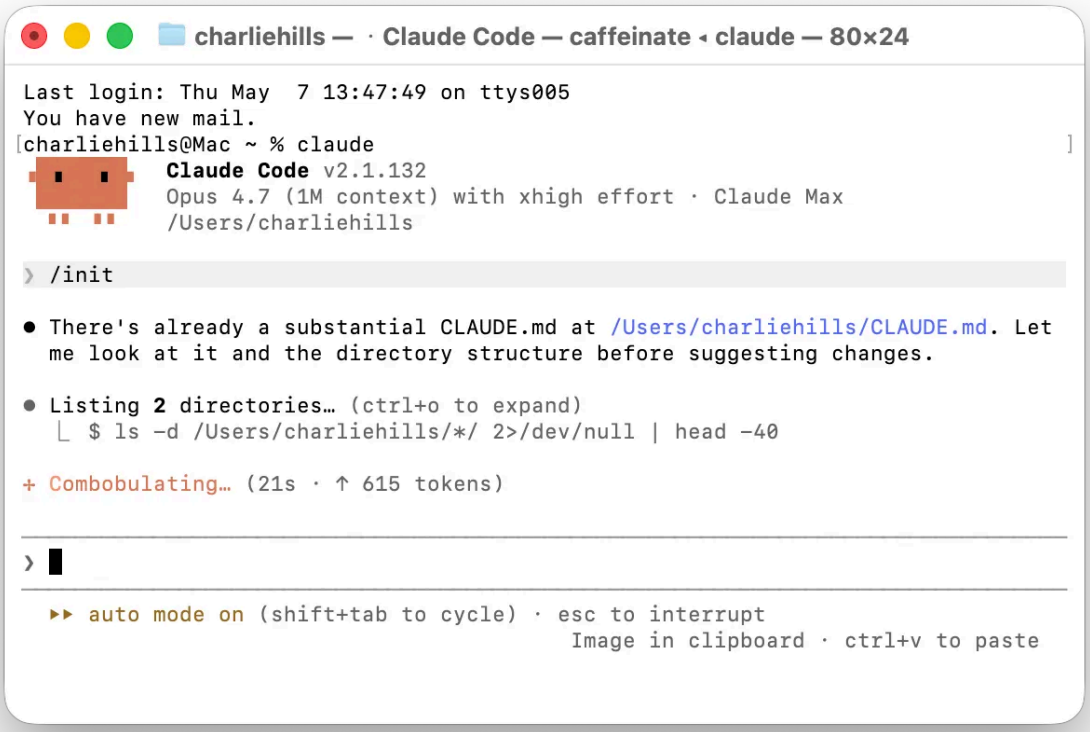
Boris Cherny’s Claude.md

Run /init write the first version. *The rest writes itself.*



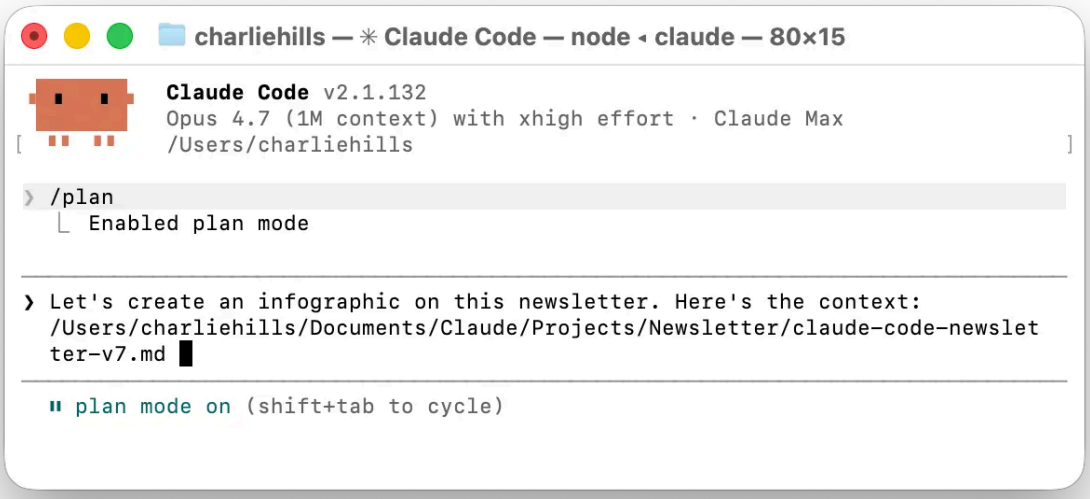
3. Plan Mode

This is what stopped me being scared.

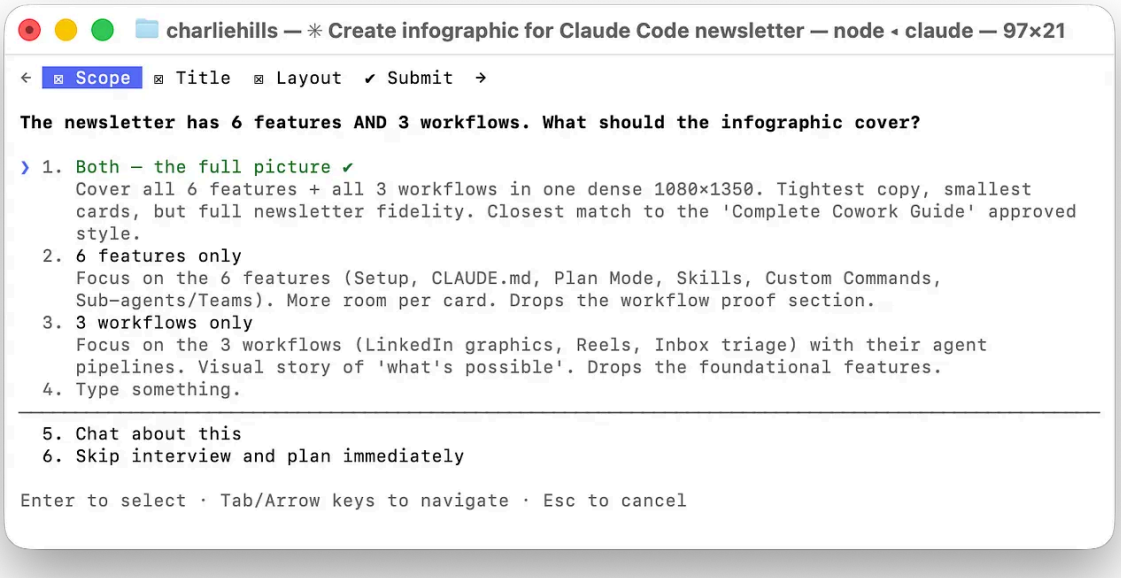
Look at **Boris Cherny's** (the engineer who built Claude Code) own CLAUDE.md file, the very first rule under "Workflow Orchestration" was *"enter plan mode for any non-trivial task"*. I have built this exact rule into every Claude Code workflow I run.

If you just say "go" without a plan, it might do something you did not intend. *Like delete a file.* Or rewrite something you did not want rewritten.

Plan Mode shows you exactly what Claude will do *before* it does it.



You read the plan. You approve. *Then* Claude acts.



If the plan is wrong, you tell Claude what to fix. It rewrites the plan. You loop until it is right. Activate it by typing `/plan`, or hit `Shift+Tab` to toggle it mid-session.

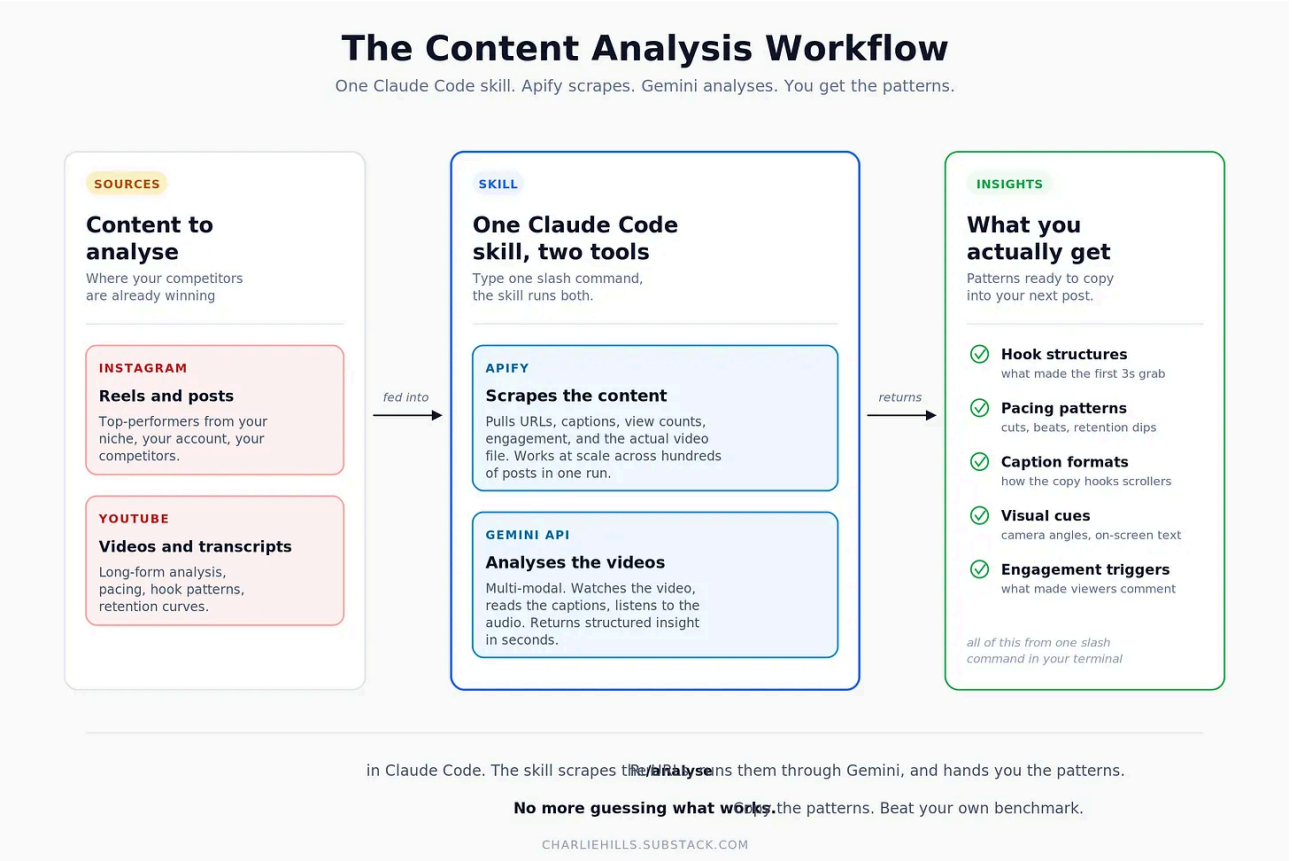
There is a second reason: **it saves your usage credits.** A failed run costs more tokens than 10 minutes of planning. If you are using Claude Code seriously, you will hit your usage limits fast unless you plan first.

4. Skills

Skills are how Claude becomes your specific team.

A skill is a folder with instructions. Same idea in Chat, Cowork, and Code. But Code is where it gets *spicy*, because Claude Code can hit APIs the others cannot.

The **Gemini API** is my favourite. Gemini is multi-modal where Claude is not. I feed it an Instagram Reel or a YouTube video and pair it with **Apify** for scraping, you have a content-analysis machine running inside your terminal.



Paste your Gemini key into Claude Code and Claude becomes a ***cyborg LLM***.

Last week I gave away a load of my Claude skill for free.

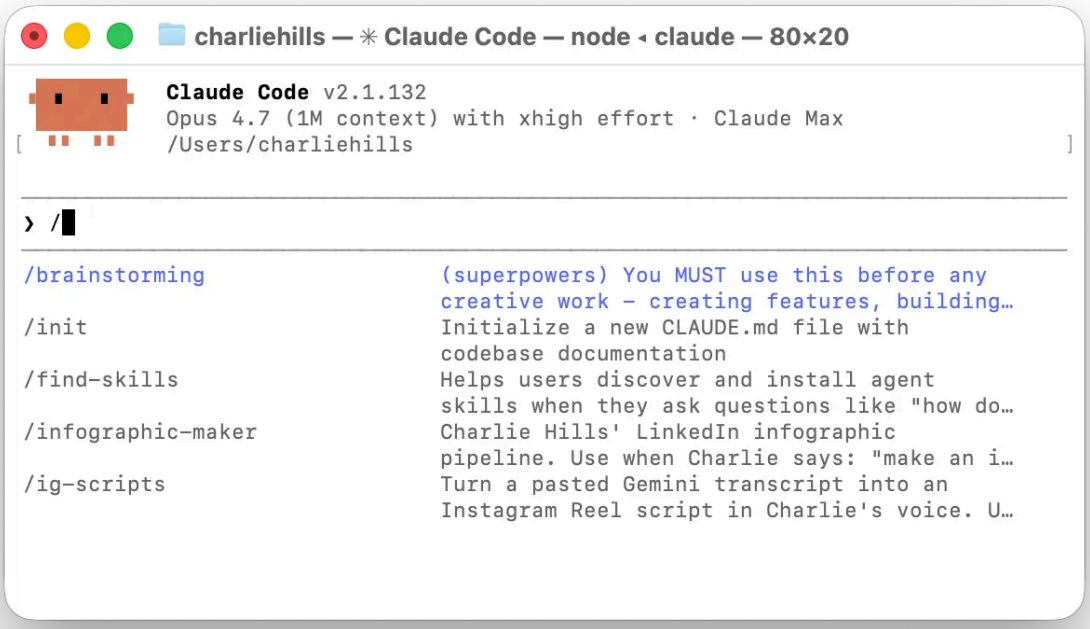
Drop them into Claude Code, Cowork, Chat, or any interface that supports skills. Writing, design, video, plus a few that would bore you.

Grab the skills library → https://github.com/charlie947/social-media-skills

5. Custom Commands

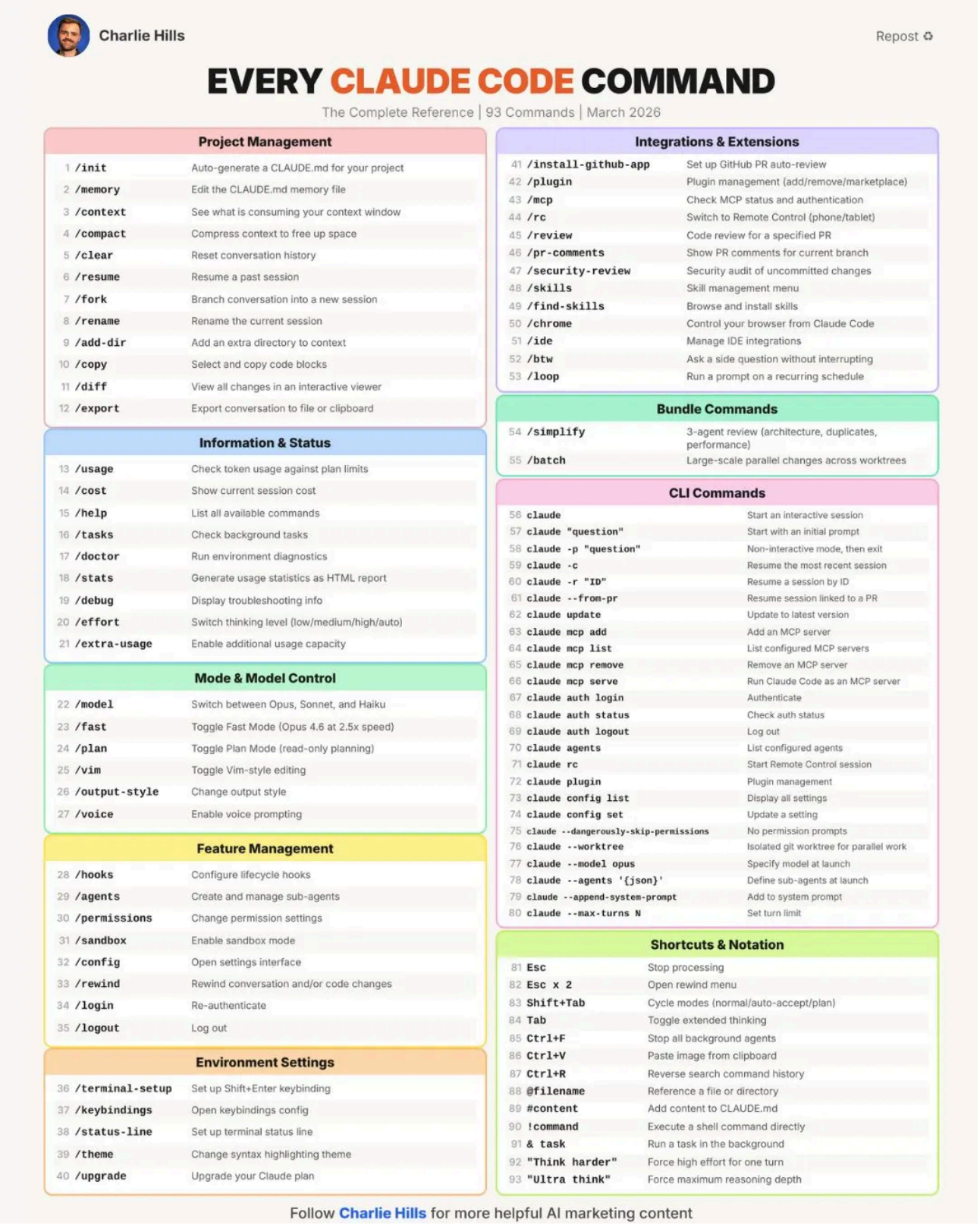
Most of the time in Claude Code, you just type. *"Help me do something."* Claude reads CLAUDE.md, picks the right skill, and goes.

But there is a layer above that. **Custom slash commands.**



Claude Code already ships with hundreds of built-in slash commands. Session tools, task tools, code review, init, bug reports, etc. You did not have to build any of these.

They are sitting there waiting:



Type `/` and have a scroll. There is probably already a command for the thing you were about to write a 200-word prompt for.

But where it gets *spicy*: **you can add your own.**

A custom command is one markdown file saved to `~/.claude/commands/`. It shows up in the same menu, alongside the built-ins, ready to fire.

To create your own, do not write the file by hand. Build the workflow with Claude first. When it works end to end, just say: *“save this as a custom command we can execute.”* Claude writes the file, names the command, wires it up.

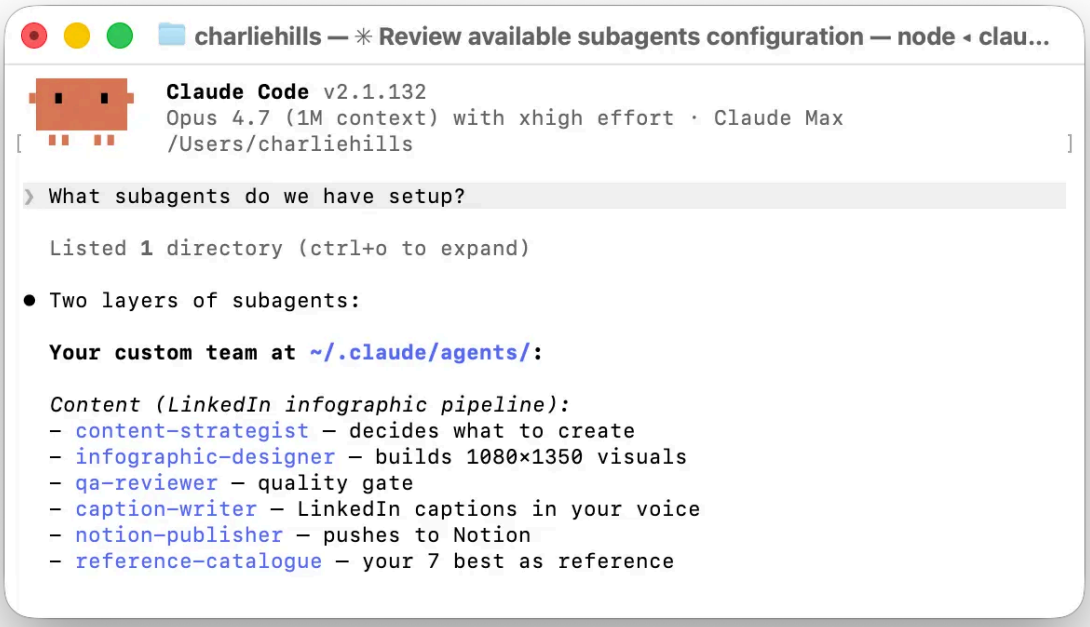
6. Sub-agents and Agent Teams

This is the feature that made Claude Code feel like a team.

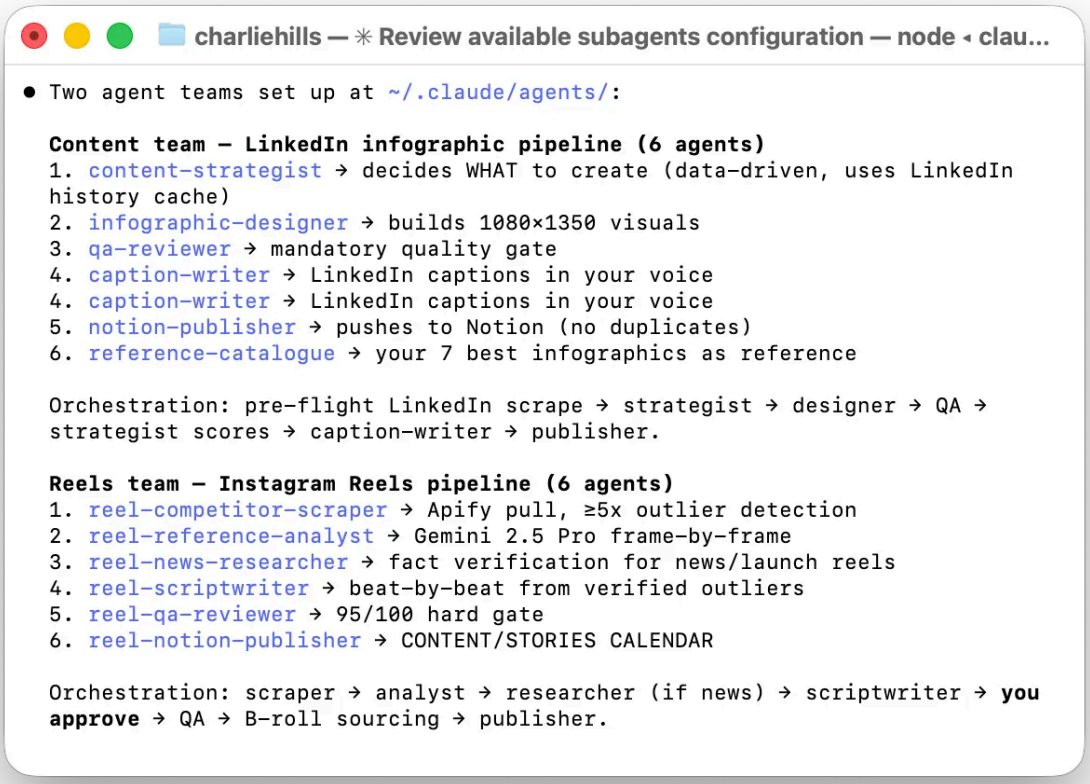
A **sub-agent** is a specialist Claude that runs in its own context.

You hand it a task, it goes off and does it, then reports back to the main session.

I use sub-agents for *research*, *scraping*, *drafting*, and *review* - anything where I want focus without polluting the main conversation.



An **agent team** is a full **production pipeline**. Multiple agents, working in parallel, each with their own role and their own context, all coordinating through a shared task list.



I built these in 6 weeks. I described what I wanted in plain English, *like I was briefing a clever new hire*.

I knew the features existed, had an idea of what I wanted to build, and told Claude to do the rest.

It's that simple.

12 weeks ago, I was scared to open the terminal.

I am not a developer. I am not overly technical.

But the gap between *"I cannot do that"* and *"I run my content business on this"* was weeks of typing what I wanted into a text box.

If you have been avoiding Claude Code because it looks technical, this is the email that says you can stop.

Have a play with it :)